

Once farming started, people began trading in markets. They had to remember exactly how many things they owned, sold, and bought, otherwise people would cheat each other. So the farmers started keeping records. To do this, they could make notches in sticks or bones ...



... or knots in string.

In Iraq, they made marks in lumps of wet clay from a river. When the clay hardened in the sun, it made a permanent record.

In doing this, the farmers of Iraq invented not just written numbers but writing itself. It was the start of civilization – and it was all triggered by numbers.



4000–2000 BC

The first symbols were circles and cones like the old tokens, but as the Babylonians got better at sharpening their wooden pens, the symbols turned into small, sharp wedges.

For a ONE they made a mark like this:

To write numbers up to nine, they simply made more marks:

2 was 3 was 4 was

When they got to 10, they turned the symbol on its side ...

... and when they got to 60, they turned it upright again.

So this is how the Babylonians would have written the number 99:

= 99
60 30 9

